

Workshop Session 2 | Achieving Ocean Sustainability through Voluntary Commitments

Discussion Paper

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The aim of this paper is to provide preparatory background material as well as initial ideas and guidance for workshop session 1 on “Achieving Ocean Sustainability through Voluntary Commitments” during the 4th Potsdam Ocean Governance Workshop to be held on 13-14 December 2017 in Potsdam.

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1 Background

In recent years, goal-based governance regimes combined with pledging and review systems for national actions have become popular in environmental and sustainability policy, most notably in the climate regime. In ocean governance this approach has been embraced by calling for and pledging of voluntary commitments (VCs), an important tool especially in the context of the implementation of sustainable development goal (SDG) 14 on the conservation and sustainable use of coastal and marine resources (UNGA 2015). In the run up to the United Nations Ocean Conference, held in June 2017 to support the implementation of SDG 14, “all stakeholders”¹ were encouraged to take action and register VCs targeting SDG 14 within the framework of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development (henceforth 2030 Agenda). By the end of the Ocean Conference on 9 June 2017, 1328 VCs had been registered through the conference website (IISD 2017); by mid of November 2017, the total number of commitments registered had reached 1406².

VCs as a tool of goal-based governance entail opportunities and challenges when it comes to generating outputs and orchestrate actions towards achieving SDG14 and the tracking and reviewing of these. To be effective, goal-based governance regimes require, among others, concretisation of targets through indicators and “formalized commitments”, and clear criteria and effective mechanisms and instruments for tracking of progress (Biermann et al. 2017; Pinter et al. 2017). Especially the definition of clear criteria and development of a suitable reporting system will be relevant for ensuring efficacy of commitments, monitoring of progress and detecting of inconsistent, ineffective or missing action. The Call for Action³ of the June Ocean Conference calls upon all stakeholders to conserve and sustainably use the oceans, seas and marine resources for sustainable development by, inter alia, committing to implementing voluntary commitments made in the context of the Conference, and by contributing to the follow-up and review process of the 2030 Agenda by providing an input to the High-level Political Forum on Sustainable Development (HLPF)⁴ on the implementation of Goal 14, including on opportunities to strengthen progress in the future. Stakeholders are also to consider further ways and means to support the timely and effective implementation of Goal 14, taking into account the discussions at the high-level political forum during its first cycle.

The UN system is however not the only framework within which commitments on ocean action have been or are being pledged. The annual Our Ocean Conferences were initiated by the U.S. Department of State and John Kerry’s Administration in 2014. The Our Ocean Conferences aim to provide a forum “to separate the walkers from the talkers”⁵ by establishing a platform for actors and stakeholders to pledge new, significant, and impactful actions that will tangibly advance ocean conservation. While the first Our Ocean Conference in 2014 rendered 31 commitments in various action fields (e.g.

¹ i.e. “... Governments, the United Nations system, other intergovernmental organizations, international and regional financial institutions, non-governmental organizations and civil society organizations, academic and research institutions, the scientific community, the private sector, philanthropic organizations and other actors - individually or in partnership – ...”, see <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/> (accessed 17 November 2017)

² <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/> (accessed 17 November 2017)

³ <https://oceanconference.un.org/callforaction> (accessed 28 November 2017)

⁴ <https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/hlpf> (accessed 05 December 2017)

⁵ Karmenu Vella, closing remarks on day 2 of the 2017 Our Ocean Conference, 6 October 2017, https://ec.europa.eu/commission/commissioners/2014-2019/vella/announcements/our-ocean-conference-day-2-closing-remarks_en (accessed 29 November 2017)

marine conservation, fisheries, pollution, ocean acidification, capacity building)⁶, the 2017 Our Ocean Conference which was hosted by the European Commission and taking place in Malta already counted 437 “measurable and tangible” commitments.

This workshop session will analyse experiences with VCs as one component of ocean governance and review the challenges and opportunities of these in ocean governance, especially with regard to the implementation, follow-up and review of SDG 14 and possibly other ocean related SDGs. By learning from the SDG 14 example and from experiences made with other goal-based governance regimes (UNFCCC & Paris Agreement; Convention on Biological Diversity), the workshop session will further discuss options, criteria and processes for a global registry of all ocean-related commitments made for better assessment of actions towards SDG 14 . Ultimately, the development of an effective system for reporting and tracking of ocean VCs could also be a test case for the 2030 Agenda as a whole and inform the development of similar systems for other SDGs.

2 Voluntary commitments in ocean governance

The following sections will briefly analyse the commitments made under The United Nations Ocean Conference 2017 and the Our Ocean Conference 2017, including the criteria that were set towards design, registration and acceptance of commitments, and the recent state of registration, reporting and follow-up processes for these commitments.

2.1 The United Nations Ocean Conference 2017

The United Nations Ocean Conference brought about a wealth of VCs that were registered from the opening of “The Ocean Conference Registry of Commitments”⁷ on 15 February 2017 until the start of the Conference in June 2017, throughout the Conference and thereafter. A list of 1380 VCs that had been registered or announced before and during the United Nations Ocean Conference (United Nations 2017, Annex 2, p. 59-134) was one of the three major outcomes of the conference⁸, beside the political declaration “Our ocean, our future: call for action” (United Nations 2017: 5-9) and the summaries of the seven partnership dialogues (United Nations 2017, para 76-218).

By mid of November 2017, the number of VCs pledged by Governments, the UN system and various other entities and actors had reached a total of 1406⁹ (see Annex 8, Figure 1). A brief overview of these VCs is presented in Annex 8 at the end of this paper. A more in-depth analysis of these VCs is available from the Conference webpage as PDF¹⁰.

2.1.1 The United Nations Ocean Conference Registry of Commitments

Along with a call for VCs “that aim to contribute to the implementation of Sustainable Development Goal 14”¹¹, criteria were provided through the United Nations Ocean Conference’s webpage to guide

⁶ <http://ourocean2016.org/2014-commitments/> (accessed 18 November 2017)

⁷ <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/> (accessed 29 November 2017)

⁸ Ibid.; <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/#followup> (accessed 25 November 2017)

⁹ <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/> > Statistics (accessed 25 November 2017)

¹⁰ <https://oceanconference.un.org/> and https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/content/documents/17193OCVC_in_depth_analysis.pdf (accessed 05 December 2017)

¹¹ Guidance on Voluntary Commitments:

actors in selecting and defining suitable commitments. A guidance note was distributed containing criteria for the registration of voluntary initiatives through The Ocean Conferences Registry of Commitments. According to these, VCs addressing SDG 14 should ¹²:

- Advance implementation of SDG 14 and associated targets, reflecting inter-linkages between SDG 14 and other Sustainable Development Goals;
- Respect principles of the UN and legal framework in force for the oceans;
- Build on existing successful efforts (scaling it up, new phase, etc.) or introduce a new one;
- Include means of implementation – such as finance or capacity building – as an element to help ensure longevity and sustainability of the initiative;
- Provide access to additional information on the commitments (e.g. website, contacts);
- Follow SMART Criteria (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Resource based, with Time-based deliverables).

A registration form was provided to register commitments along with the online registration system^{13,14}, gathering information and data on each of the registered commitments including SDG 14 targets addressed and estimates of interlinkages with other SDGs (see Table 1). VCs could be submitted by “all relevant stakeholders”, such as “Governments, UN system, intergovernmental organizations, international and regional financial institutions, scientific community, private sector, philanthropic organizations and other actors” individually or in partnership, as long as they “contribute to the implementation of Sustainable Development Goal 14”¹⁵. VCs had to fulfill the SMART criteria mentioned above to be allowed to register.

The registry will remain open for registration of new voluntary commitments.

2.1.2 Follow-up and review of voluntary commitments on SDG 14

The High-level Political Forum on Sustainable Development (HLPF)

The HLPF is the main United Nations platform on sustainable development and has a central role in the follow-up and review of the 2030 Agenda and the SDGs at the global level. The current process foresees the reporting by countries of actions through Voluntary National Reviews (VNRs) to the HLPF and annual progress reports on the SDGs by the Secretary-General in cooperation with the UN system (Persson et al. 2016). At the 2018 HLPF meeting¹⁶, 48 countries will be presenting their VNRs. The HLPF also undertakes annual thematic reviews of the SDGs, including cross-cutting issues. In 2017, SDG 14 was among the first goals to be reviewed by the HLPF¹⁷, in addition to SDG 1, SDG 2,

<https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/content/documents/12816The%20Ocean%20Conference%20-%20Guidance%20on%20Voluntary%20Commitments%20final.pdf>

¹² ibid.

¹³ <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/register/> (accessed 25 November 2017)

¹⁴ “Voluntary Commitment Registration Form”

https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/content/documents/14235Ocean_Conference_Voluntary_Commitment_Registrati on_reference_form.docx (accessed 25 November 2017)

¹⁵ <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/#followup>, accessed 21 November 2017

¹⁶ <https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/hlpf/2018> (accessed 05 December 2017)

¹⁷ <https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/hlpf/2017>; for a background note on the HLPF review of SDG 14 see <https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/content/documents/14375SDG14format-revOD.pdf> (accessed 06 December 2017)

SDG 3, SDG 5 and SDG 9. The 2018 HLPF meeting will be reviewing SDG 6, SDG 7, SDG 11, SDG 12, SDG 15 and SDG 17. The topic of ocean is interlinked with most of the SDGs being discussed, such as energy, sustainable consumption and production, and water, and might also be reflected in some of the VNRs presented by Member States. Further relevant information from the science-policy-interface shall be provided to the HLPF through the Global Sustainable Development Report (United Nations 2015, para 78-91).

The 2030 Agenda's resolution document provides a long list of principles and criteria for the envisaged "robust, voluntary, effective, participatory, transparent and integrated follow-up and review framework" and a "global indicator framework" (UNGA 2015, para 72-91). But despite these provisions, further steps towards operationalising the HLPF's work (UNGA 2016a, b) and first SDG reviews by the HLPF in 2017, some aspects of the follow-up and review process still remain to be developed and specified such as the indicator framework currently being developed by the IAEG-SDGs^{18,19} (see also Beisheim 2016; Nilsson 2017; Pinter et al. 2017).

Communities of Ocean Action

As mentioned before, in the United Nations Ocean Conference's political declaration "Our ocean, our future: call for action", Member States called upon all stakeholders to "welcome the follow-up on the partnership dialogues and commit to implementing [our] respective voluntary commitments made in the context of the Conference" (UNGA 2017, para 13 (t)). Further, all stakeholders were called upon to "contribute to the follow-up and review process of the 2030 Agenda by providing an input to the high-level political forum on sustainable development on the implementation of Goal 14..." (UNGA 2017, para 13 (u)). To follow-up on the implementation of these voluntary commitments, to catalyse and generate new voluntary commitments, and to facilitate collaboration and networking amongst different actors in support of SDG 14, the United Nations has launched nine thematic multi-stakeholder Communities of Ocean Action around the following areas:

1. Mangroves
2. Coral reefs
3. Ocean acidification
4. Marine and coastal ecosystems management
5. Sustainable fisheries
6. Marine pollution
7. Sustainable blue economy
8. Scientific knowledge, research capacity development and transfer of marine technology
9. Implementation of international law as reflected in United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea

All stakeholders with registered voluntary commitments, either at the Conference or subsequently, may join any of the Communities of Ocean Action to stay informed and take part in supporting activities, including workshops, webinars, expert discussions and networking.²⁰

¹⁸ <https://unstats.un.org/sdgs/> (accessed 05 December 2017)

¹⁹ A global indicator framework for the SDGs and targets of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, developed by the Inter-Agency and Expert Group on Sustainable Development Indicators, was adopted by the General Assembly on 7 July 2017 (cp. <https://unstats.un.org/sdgs/indicators/indicators-list/>, accessed 22 November 2017)

²⁰ <https://oceanconference.un.org/coa>

To support the work of these Communities of Ocean Action, designated focal points have been identified for each thematic area from among those actors that have registered voluntary commitments in the online registry, who will work together with the United Nations Secretary-General's Special Envoy for the Ocean²¹ Mr. Peter Thomson and the UN Department of Economic and Social Affairs. In collaboration with the UN DESA and Mr. Thomson, focal points are expected to:

- Generate multi-stakeholder interest and engagement in the Communities of Ocean Action and in the follow-up to The Ocean Conference in general;
- Consult broadly with the relevant community to provide assessments of progress of voluntary commitments, and collect examples of successful implementation of voluntary commitments;
- Consult with the relevant thematic community to identify challenges to implementation of voluntary commitments;
- Help identify gaps in implementation in the Ocean Action area and spur the creation and registration of new voluntary commitments by all stakeholders;
- Collect expertise in areas related to the community of action and help channel best practices and policies to the voluntary commitments follow-up process.

The following outputs are expected to be accomplished from these Communities of Ocean Action by the next anticipated Ocean Conference in 2020:

- Assessment on the progress of registered voluntary commitments in the areas related to the Community of Ocean Action;
- Increased registrations of new voluntary commitments in the area related to the Community of Ocean Action;
- Increased multi-stakeholder interest and engagement in the Community of Ocean Action and in the follow-up to The Ocean Conference.

The Partnerships for SDGs Online Platform

UN resolution 66/288 on “The Future We Want” mandated the Secretary-General to compile commitments made at Rio+20 and facilitate access to other registries that have compiled commitments, in an internet-based registry (United Nations 2012, Para 283). This registry is being administered by UNDESA and contains multi-stakeholder partnerships and commitments related to Agenda 21, the Johannesburg Plan of Implementation, the Millennium Declaration, the outcome document of the United Nations Conference on Sustainable Development (Rio+20) entitled “The Future We Want”, the Third International Conference on Small Island Developing States, and the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. It has recently been renamed to “Partnerships for SDGs Online Platform”²² to allow the registration of partnerships and commitments in support of the SDGs.

In line with the 2030 Agenda, which in paragraph 84 recognizes that the regular reviews conducted by the HLPF shall also promote a platform for partnerships, including through the participation of

²¹ <https://oceanconference.un.org/SpecialEnvoy> (accessed 05 December 2017)

²² <https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/partnerships/> (accessed 05 December 2017)

major groups and other stakeholders, since 2016, a Partnership Exchange has been organized in connection with the HLPF sessions to review the role of multi-stakeholder partnerships in driving implementation of the SDGs. These Partnership Exchanges have also reviewed and highlighted partnerships that have been registered in the online SDGs platform.

2.2 Our Ocean Conference 2017

The 2017 Our Ocean Conference (OOC), the fourth high-level conference in a series initiated by the U.S. Department 2014, was hosted by the European Union (EU) in Malta on 5-6 October 2017. The Conference's aim was "to inspire joint solutions and ambitious commitments for safe, secure, clean and sustainably managed oceans"²³ and to follow-on the previous conferences held in Washington D.C., U.S. (2014 and 2016) and in Valparaíso, Chile (2015). The EU understood the chairing of this conference also as a means to complement the EU's international ocean governance initiative²⁴ and thus put great efforts in advancing the procedures taken to ensure a high quality of commitments made through the 2017 Our Ocean Conference. Topic areas covered by the OOC 2017 included, besides the established ones (marine pollution, marine protected areas, sustainable fisheries, and climate-related impacts on the ocean), for the first time "blue economy" and "maritime security"²⁵. Correspondingly, the call for commitments to the OOC 2017 also sought VCs from industry and the private sector²⁶.

Further, the tracking of progress was seen as a "key part" of the conference, resulting in a set of criteria provided to guide the registration of commitments (see Table 2, page 15) and a rigorous cross-checking and revising of submitted commitments. Multiple assessors at the European Commission (DG Mare) inspected submissions along those criteria to make sure that VCs were significant and impactful, and that outcomes will make a meaningful contribution to reducing marine pollution, managing aquatic resources, mitigating climate change or setting up marine sanctuaries. Where commitments and information provided upon submission did not meet the criteria or provisions of the registration form (see Table 1, page 13), contact to the committing party was sought to have commitments revised accordingly. Considering the number VCs registered, this is a considerable effort of (manual) quality assessment which was, besides others, also made to ease future assessments of progress by asking for quantifiable and consistent information. Overall, 437 commitments had been accepted until the evening before the 2017 OOC in Malta²⁷, yielding EUR 7.2 billion in financial pledges and "2.5 million km² of additional Marine Protected Areas". Of these, 100 VCs had been registered by the private sector.

Beyond the registration of new commitments, the EU also took action to track progress on the VCs of previous OOCs. As DG Mare-Commissioner Karmenu Vella concluded at the OOC 2017 in Malta, the tracking had yielded that "half of the previously announced 283 commitments – 47% – have now been completed", and that "[a]nother 46% are fully active"²⁸. He further announced that the EU is willing to invest and setup a tracking mechanism as further outcome of the 2017 OOC in addition to

²³ http://ourocean2017.org/sites/default/files/O2%20Concept%20Paper_FINAL_en.pdf (accessed 29 November 2017)

²⁴ Ibid.

²⁵ http://ourocean2017.org/sites/default/files/O2%20Concept%20Paper_FINAL_en.pdf (accessed 29 November 2017)

²⁶ Ibid.

²⁷ http://www.ourocean2017.org/sites/default/files/ooc-2017-list-of-commitments_en.pdf and

<http://data.consilium.europa.eu/doc/document/ST-12945-2017-INIT/en/pdf> (accessed 29 November 2017)

²⁸ https://ec.europa.eu/commission/commissioners/2014-2019/vella/announcements/our-ocean-conference-day-2-closing-remarks_en (accessed 29 November 2017)

the list of commitments and an interactive map of VCs²⁹. All OOCs follow a specific protocol that is handed over from host to host, and which has been revised over the course of all four OOCs. The protocol foresees the “tracking” of commitments and progress on these made under the previous OOC.

3 Further governance arenas employing voluntary commitments

Goal-based governance and governance that builds on cooperative instruments such as VCs has become more widespread in global environmental governance in recent years (Weiss 2014). Other prominent governance regimes that employ voluntary instruments through pledge and review mechanisms for addressing collective action problems in environmental governance are those for climate (Paris Agreement) and biodiversity (Convention on Biological Diversity).

Under UNFCCC’ Paris Agreement, Parties are required to pledge “nationally determined contributions” (NDCs) in order to meet the agreement’s goals of combatting climate change and “[h]olding the increase in the global average temperature to well below 2 °C above pre-industrial levels and to pursue efforts to limit the temperature increase to 1.5 °C above pre-industrial levels” (UNFCCC 2015). An interim “NDC Registry” was set up at the COP 21 to help Parties register their NDCs, and to provide a transparent tracking mechanism for policy-makers and the civil society through a public registry which is maintained by the UNFCCC Secretariat³⁰. This interim NDC registry currently contains the NDCs of 164 Parties as PDFs but provides no further analytical features³¹. Other institutions have come up with tracking “systems” to improve transparency and reviewing of pledges and actions, such as the “Climate Action Tracker”³² which is produced by a consortium of independent research institutes and supported by the Potsdam Institute for Climate Impact research (PIK Potsdam). The German Development Institute launched an interactive tool to facilitate analysis of NDCs, the “NDC Explorer”, as part of a web-based research and dialogue platform³³.

Parties to the Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD) were called to “announce commitments or actions”, individually or through partnerships and co-operations, in order to support the CBD, the Strategic Plan for Biodiversity 2011-2020, and the Aichi Biodiversity Targets³⁴. A total of 131 actions is listed as VCs and coalitions, announced during the 13th meeting of the Conference of the Parties of the Convention on Biological Diversity (COP 13) in December 2016 in Cancun, Mexico³⁵. Currently, there exists no central registry of CBD commitments, but an expansion and more prominent inclusion of VCs in the post-2020 global biodiversity framework is apparently under discussion³⁶.

²⁹ See <http://www.ourocean2017.org/our-ocean-commitments> (accessed 29 November 2017)

³⁰ http://unfccc.int/focus/ndc_registry/items/9433.php (accessed 29 November 2017)

³¹ <http://www4.unfccc.int/ndcregistry/Pages/Home.aspx> (accessed 29 November 2017)

³² <http://climateactiontracker.org/> (accessed 06 December 2017)

³³ <http://klimalog.die-gdi.de/en> (accessed 06 December 2017)

³⁴ <https://www.cbd.int/2011-2020/actions/ccc> (accessed 29 November 2017)

³⁵ <https://www.cbd.int/2011-2020/actions/ccc> (accessed 29 November 2017)

³⁶ Andreas Obrecht, UN Environment; presentation at a workshop of the Fridtjof Nansen Institute on “Rethinking Biodiversity Governance (RBG)”, 14.9.2017, https://www.fni.no/getfile.php/136009/Dokumenter/CBD%20preparations%20for%20a%20post%202020%20Strategic%20Plan_v2.pdf (accessed 29 November 2017)

A further governance arena which make use of VCs as instrument is the UN Environment Assembly (UNEA) which in 2017 invited VCs “towards a pollution-free planet” to be submitted to the UNEA-3 meeting in Kenya in December 2017³⁷, also providing a webpage to register VCs³⁸.

³⁷ <http://wedocs.unep.org/bitstream/item/22252/Guidance%20Note%20Voluntary%20Commitments%20final%20-%202018%20July.pdf?sequence=1> (accessed 29 November 2017)

³⁸ <http://web.unep.org/environmentassembly/act-now> (accessed 29 November 2017)

4 Discussion points for the workshop

VCs on ocean actions have been made at the United Nations Ocean Conference and will continue to be made, also in view of a possible next United Nations Ocean Conference in 2020³⁹ and through other processes such as the Our Ocean Conferences which present additional contributions to achieving SDG 14. Considering these developments, a formalization and harmonization of registration and reporting procedures, including of the criteria for acceptance of pledges or types and formats of data collections, seems highly advisable. As Beisheim (2014) suggests, a solid review process provides an opportunity to “...measure and evaluate (the implementation of) these national commitments in relation to globally agreed commitments...”, bring about transparency and accountability, and enhance ownership, learning and capacity development. It has further been argued that VCs on SDG 14 pledged by Member States and other actors should be embedded in a systemic and transparent global registry of ocean commitments in order to document and coordinate actions, track their progress, identify trends and allow for learning processes (Unger et al. 2017). Germany had proposed such a global registry of ocean commitments as part of an informal submission during the Preparatory Meeting for the UN Ocean Conference (February 2017).

Besides the question of what can be learned from the different processes for VCs in ocean governance and other fields, one critical question is whether there are processes or solutions that should be included and considered in a possible “global registry of ocean commitments”. But also general questions on the utility of VCs in (ocean) governance need to be put under scrutiny to make sure that commitments pledged will generate tangible outputs.

Starting off with a round of introductions, this workshop session will seek to discuss the following questions:

What is the role of VCs in ocean governance?

- What are the challenges and opportunities of VCs in ocean governance in general, and with respect to the implementation of SDG 14 of the 2030 Agenda?
- What are the drivers behind VC evolution in ocean governance?
- What is the relation between goal-based governance through VCs and “traditional” rule-based governance, e.g. through legal instruments.

What are the experiences with existing VC schemes and what can we learn for ocean governance?

- What can we learn from existing VC schemes in ocean governance, in particular United Nations Ocean Conference and the OOC?
- What experiences have been made with The United Nations Ocean Conference Registry of Commitments and the OCC Registry, especially in terms of the registration procedure and follow-up on VCs?
- What are relevant lessons-learned from other VC mechanism, e.g. CBD, Paris Agreement, UNEA?

³⁹ Kenya and Portugal offered to host such Conference

- What are the similarities and differences of existing VC schemes, in terms of criteria, reporting process, aims and objectives?

Feasibility, aims, and possible structure and of a future global registry of (ocean) VCs?

- What are the advantages or disadvantages of a possible global registry?
- What are supporting or hindering factors?
- What would be the main objectives and desired functions and outcomes?
- What could be building blocks for a global registry (e.g. existing registries feeding into a global system)?
- Which further criteria need to be considered when developing such a registry, e.g. with regard to the specific characteristics of ocean systems (e.g. reflecting marine regions) or indicators?
- Is there a need to differentiate the different levels of action (e.g. domestic action, action abroad, support of development cooperation)?
- Who should be in charge of such a registry and under what institutional mechanism?
- Where would a tracking system stand between (voluntary) national and (indicator-based) global level reporting to the HLPF?
- Should it be solely a SDG 14 registry or consider SDG interlinkages?
- How to improve coherence with other reporting systems with relevance for the marine environment such as under the CBD, UNEA, Paris Agreement?

Recommendations for possible next steps

- What are possible next steps to bring forth goal-based ocean governance through VCs in general?
- What could be steps towards a streamlined global registry of voluntary commitments?

5 Further reading

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Annex 1 - Information gathered in different political ocean governance processes

Table 1: Information requested on voluntary commitments to The Ocean Conference 2017 and the Our Ocean Conference 2017

	The Ocean Conference 2017 ⁴⁰	Our Ocean Conference 2017 ⁴¹
General information	Title/name of voluntary commitment	Title of commitment
	Lead entity Lead entity type ⁴²	Lead entity name Lead entity type ⁴³
	Contact information (first name, last name, title, telephone, email, headquarters)	Contact information
	Partners ⁴⁴	Partners (name & type)
	Beneficiary countries (enter names of countries)	Beneficiary country/countries/regions
	Other beneficiaries (max 200 words)	Other beneficiaries
	Website with further information (optional)	
Details on the commitments	Description of voluntary commitment (objectives, implementation methodologies, follow-up mechanisms, governance mechanisms, etc.) (max 500 words)	Description of commitment (up to 150 words) Selection of themes covered ⁴⁵ If Marine protected area (MPA) what is the MPA size (in km2)?
	Ocean basins targeted by commitments (multiple options, optional) ⁴⁶	
	Deliverables (at least one, up to four) (Description, date)	How far along is the initiative? When will the initiative be completed? Is the initiative on track according to original timeline?
	Resources mobilized towards commitment (USD) ⁴⁷	Quantification of commitments (e.g. in terms of funding amount, percentage of spatial expansion) If monetary commitment: How much has been spent?
	Start date (month/year) End date (month/year)	Expected launch date Expected date of achieving the commitment
	SDG 14 targets covered by commitment (multiple	

⁴⁰ Webpage "Register Voluntary Commitment for implementation of Goal 14":

<https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/register/> (accessed 25 November 2017)

⁴¹ Registration form provided by Stefanie Schmidt, EU Commission, DG Mare, 25 July 2017

⁴² Options: Government; United Nations entity; Intergovernmental organization; Non-governmental organization; Civil society organization; Academic institution; Scientific community; Private sector; Philanthropic organization; Other relevant actor; Partnership

⁴³ Options: Government; Intergovernmental organization; Private sector; NGO; UN Agency; Partnership; Scientific community; Philanthropic organization; Other actor

⁴⁴ "List all organizations and entities, including lead entity, that are involved in this voluntary commitment. For each partner, include, in parenthesis, its entity type (using above entity types)"

⁴⁵ Options: Marine Protected Area; Sustainable Fisheries; Marine pollution; Climate-related impacts on the ocean; Blue Economy; Maritime Security; Other (specify)

⁴⁶ Options: Global; Arctic Ocean; North Atlantic Ocean; South Atlantic Ocean; Indian Ocean; North Pacific Ocean; South Pacific Ocean; Southern Ocean

⁴⁷ Options (per resource and for each of the deliverables): type [Financing (in USD); In-kind contribution; Other, please specify; Staff/technical expertise] and description of resource

	options) ⁴⁸	
	Linkages to other SDGs and associated targets (multiple options, optional)	
		What is the impact?

⁴⁸ In addition to a list of targets, additional descriptors was provided to specify the “type of commitment” (<https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/register/>, accessed 25 November 2017)

Table 2: Comparative overview of criteria for commitments to be registered/accepted through The Ocean Conference 2017, the Our Ocean Conference 2017, sorted and aggregated

2017 UN Ocean Conference ⁴⁹	2017 Our Ocean Conference ⁵⁰
“Advance implementation of SDG 14 and associated targets, reflecting inter-linkages between SDG 14 and other Sustainable Development Goals.”	“While announcements related to the four conference themes are encouraged, significant actions related to other aspects of ocean conservation will be considered for announcement as well.” ⁵¹
“Respect principles of the United Nations and the legal framework in force for the oceans.”	
“Build on existing successful efforts (scaling it up, new phase, etc.) or introduce new one.”	Possibility to announce - fulfilment of intended commitments from previous Our Ocean conferences - expansions of previous commitments adding a significant new dimension to the previous initiative
“Include means of implementation - such as finance or capacity building - as an element to help ensure longevity and sustainability of the initiative.”	
“Provide access to additional information on the commitments (e.g. website, contacts).”	
“Follow SMART Criteria – a commitment that is Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Resource based, with Time-based deliverables.”	“Initiatives announced ... should be new, significant, and impactful actions that will tangibly advance ocean conservation.” “The goals of the Our Ocean Conferences is to have participants commit to tangible, effective actions.” In recognition of differing financial resources, technical expertise, or history of engagement on these issues, a country’s available resources and previous efforts to ocean conservation will be taken into account when deciding over qualification of commitments
“Registration of voluntary commitments can be done online starting from 15 February 2017. Submissions may include commitments made since the adoption of 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development (September 2015). Voluntary commitments may also be announced in the official meetings of the Conference.”	“We will accept significant commitments to action that have been announced prior to the conference (5-6 October 2017), as long as they were announced after the previous Our Ocean conference (15-16 September 2016).”
	<u>not</u> considered: signing of agreements, MOUs, resolutions, guidelines, or other such documents; a workshop or other one-time event ... unless it is a clear first step to a significant commitment.

⁴⁹ Guidance note on “Voluntary Commitments for the implementation of Goal 14”, <https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/content/documents/12816The%20Ocean%20Conference%20-%20Guidance%20on%20Voluntary%20Commitments%20final.pdf> (accessed 29 November 2017)

⁵⁰ Registration form provided by Stefanie Schmidt, EU Commission, DG Mare, 25 July 2017

⁵¹ Themes: Marine Protected Area; Sustainable Fisheries; Marine pollution; Climate-related impacts on the ocean; Blue Economy; Maritime Security; Other (specify) (see Table 1, page 19)

Annex 2 - Brief analysis of voluntary commitments submitted to The Ocean Conference

By mid of November 2017, a total number of 1406 VCs⁵² has been pledged by Governments, the UN system and various other entities and actors (Figure 1). The majority of these 1406 VCs was pledged by governments (44% of VCs) and non-governmental organisations (NGOs; 20% of VCs). All in all, 89 States had delivered a total of 616 VCs at this point, with between 1 and 43 (Dominican Republic) VCs per government, compared to 108 NGOs having pledged 288 VCs by mid of November 2017. The beneficiaries of the pledged 1406 VCs encompass 143 different countries with single countries receiving between 1 and 62 (Honduras) VCs.

In terms of ocean regions, the North Atlantic and South Pacific regions received together 51% of all action commitments while the two Arctic regions (Arctic Ocean and Southern Ocean) were only considered in 3% of the registered VCs each.

With respect to the individual SDG 14 targets, it is interesting to see that all 10 targets and means of implementation under SDG 14 have been addressed by the registered VCs, though with different foci:

- **Most commitments addressed target 14.2** (19%, 719 VCs), addressing “Community or Locally Managed Marine Areas” (303 VCs), “Integrated Coastal Management” (308 VCs), “Marine Spatial Planning” (207 VCs), “Large Marine Ecosystem approach” (169 VCs), “Ecosystem-based Adaptation” (236 VCs) and 107 not further specified commitments.
- The **second largest group** of targets addressed was SDG **target 14.1** with a total of 552 commitments (14%) on nutrients, plastic, shipping and other pollutants, closely followed by target 14.a on scientific research, capacity building etc. which received a remarkable number of 544 commitments (14%).
- Voluntary initiatives directed towards the conservation of coastal and marine areas (**14.5**) were proposed by **10% of all commitments** (391 VCs), proposing all the range of conservation statuses from “No take marine protected area” (109) over “Marine protected area with partial protection” (114), “Multiple use marine protected area” (158), “Locally or community managed marine areas” (180) and “MPA management and/or enforcement” (171) and 41 unspecified others.
- The **lowest number of commitments** were oriented towards action on fisheries subsidies (**target 14.6**; 3%, 96 VCs), while sustainable fishing practices were the concern of 426 VCs submitted (target 14.4, 426 VCs).

The 1406 VCs pledged by mid of November address multiple targets, as illustrated in Figure 2. On average, each VCs foresees actions on 2.7 targets and addressed 5.4 different sub-types of commitments. For example, for the 391 commitments that aimed at taking action on target 14.5, 773 “types of commitments” were specified upon registration (Figure 3), with “locally or community managed areas” (180 listings) making the largest contribution of area-based voluntary measures.

⁵² <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/> > Statistics (accessed 25 November 2017)



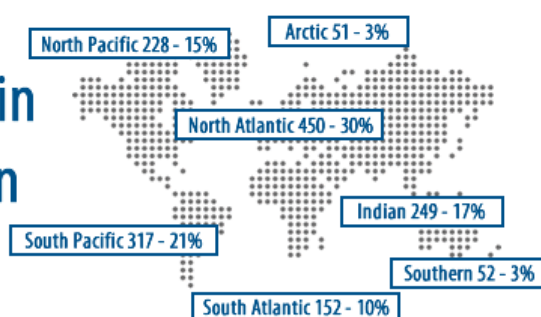
Voluntary Commitments **At a glance**

Voluntary Commitments can address multiple targets and ocean basins.

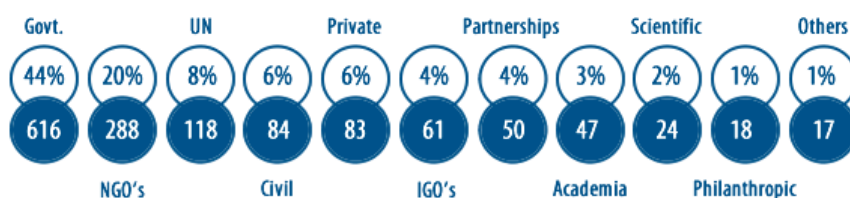
1406

Total Commitments

Ocean Basin Breakdown



Entities



SDG Targets



Figure 1: Total number and brief characterization of commitments registered through the UN's The Ocean Conference website by mid of November 2017⁵³

⁵³ Source and copyright: <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/> (accessed 17 November 2017)

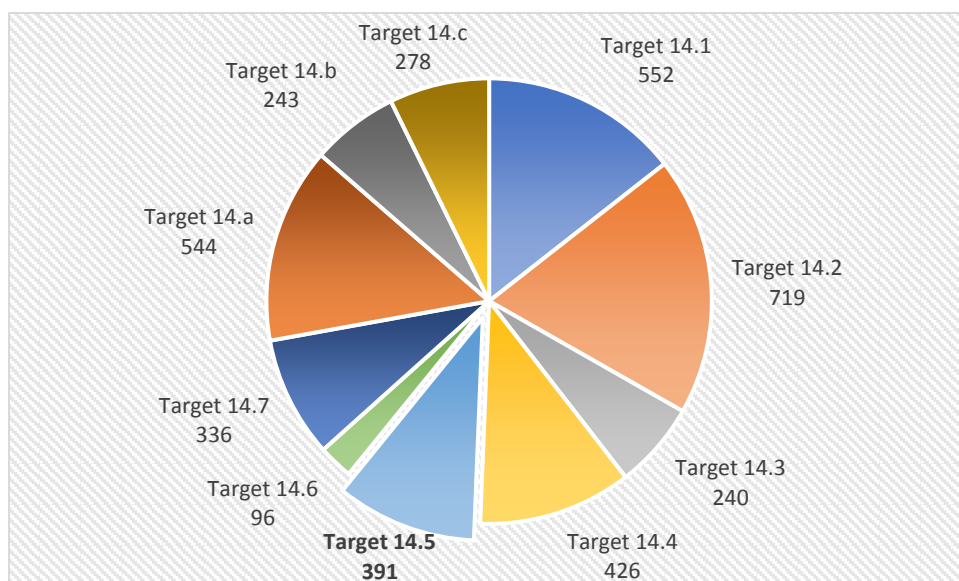


Figure 2: Number of targets addressed by voluntary commitments on SDG 14 by November 2017 (total: 1406)⁵⁴

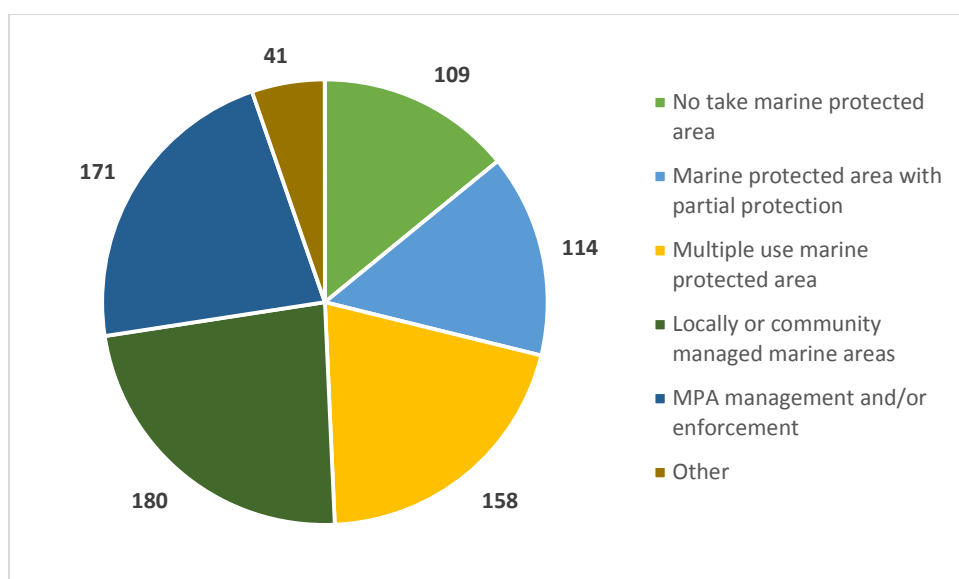


Figure 3: Types of commitments specified made under **target 14.5**⁵⁵

A more in-depth analysis of all VCs pledged is available on the webpage of the United Nations Ocean Conference as PDF⁵⁶.

⁵⁴ Data source: <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/> > Statistics (accessed 25 November 2017)

⁵⁵ Data source: <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/> > Statistics (accessed 25 November 2017)

⁵⁶ <https://oceanconference.un.org/> and https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/content/documents/17193OCVC_in_depth_analysis.pdf (accessed 05 December 2017)